

SAMANTHA CERVANTES

Maxwell School of Citizenship and Public Affairs, Syracuse University

mscervan@syr.edu

(858) 205-9998

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Administration

2022 – 2027 (expected)

Syracuse University, Maxwell School

Fields: Education Policy and Urban Economics

Advisors: Amy E. Schwartz and Michah W. Rothbart

M.S., Applied Economics with Honors

2022

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

Certificate in Applied Statistics

2019

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

B.A., Business Administration, minor in Political Science

2018

Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Urban Policy, Education Policy, Neighborhood Effects, Economics of Crime

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

The Impacts of High-Intensity Streetlights on Academic Outcomes: Evidence from a Crime Deterrence Experiment

with Amy E. Schwartz

Governments increasingly use place-based interventions to reduce crime, but their consequences for residents, including children, are rarely evaluated beyond crime itself. We study these broader consequences using a 2016 randomized intervention in which the New York Police Department assigned high-intensity streetlights —each emitting 600,000 lumens, four times the brightness of Yankee Stadium’s lights— to high-crime public housing developments. Linking the experimental data to administrative records of public school students and incident-level geocoded crime and arrest data, we find that although exposure to nighttime and daytime index crime, arrests, and incidents involving underage victims fell substantially in high-dose developments, those assigned greater lighting intensity, achievement did not improve on average. This null masks two offsetting patterns. Students in high-rise buildings, where fewer apartments fall within the lights’ reach, gained 0.11 standard deviations in math and 0.10 in reading, while students in low-rise buildings, with a larger fraction of exposed students, lost 0.22 in math, a difference of 0.33 standard deviations. The penalty is largest for the shortest buildings and declines steadily with each additional story. This attenuation with building height is more consistent with direct residential light exposure than with the possibility that students in shorter buildings received smaller crime reductions. The achievement gradient by building height is absent among students living just outside high-dose developments, while no comparable safety gradient by building height appears within them.

Instead, consistent with sleep disruption, the losses concentrate among girls at puberty-relevant ages and in math rather than reading. Differences in post-treatment school mobility and school quality may also account for part of the achievement gradient. A policy can therefore reduce crime while imposing academic costs on the children living closest to it, making its net effect depend on intensity and on how the built environment allocates exposure.

Working Papers

Hold Harmless for Whom? The Impact of COVID Era Policies for School Funding, Teachers, and Students.

with Michah W. Rothbart and Amy E. Schwartz (R&R at *Education Finance and Policy*)

How a Good School in the Neighborhood Affects Academic Outcomes

with Sarah Cordes, Jeehee Han, Amy E. Schwartz, & **Cervantes, S.**

Works in Progress

The Long-Term Impact of Neighborhood Violence on Youth Outcomes

with Amy E. Schwartz

The Impact of a Crime Deterrence Intervention on Political Behavior

with Ying Shi

Housing Market Responses to Salient Police Interventions: Experimental Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights

with Alexander Cardazzi

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate, Center for Policy Research	2022 –
Professors Michah W. Rothbart and Amy E. Schwartz	

Research Assistant, Center for Competitiveness Studies	2019 – 2022
Professor Guillermo Abdel Musik, ITAM	

Investment Consultant, Profuturo Pensiones	2018 – 2019
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TEACHING

Syracuse University (Graduate-level)

Quantitative Analysis	Spring 2024, Spring 2025
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Public Budgeting	Fall 2022, Summer 2023, Summer 2024
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Guest Lecturer: Education Policy, Quantitative Analysis	Spring 2025
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PRESENTATIONS

Upcoming: Urban Economics Association (UEA); NYU Furman Center; Southern Economics Association (SEA);

2026: American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association (AREUEA); FLX Economics of Education Workshop; Capital District Applied Microeconomics Workshop; Association for Education Finance

and Policy (AEFP)

2025: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

2024: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM); Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP); Public Finance and Budgeting Northeastern Workshop

2023: Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

GRANTS & AWARDS

First Place, Graduate Student Poster Session

2026

Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University

Summer Dissertation Fellowship

Syracuse University

Ph.D. Department Research Grant

2025

Syracuse University

Financial Inclusion Essay Award

2021

National Banking and Securities Commission

SERVICE

Graduate Student Representative

2026 – 2027

Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University

Ad Hoc Referee: *Educational Researcher, Journal of Behavioral Public Administration*

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Statistical software: Stata, R, QGIS, Python

REFERENCES

Amy Ellen Schwartz

aeschwar@udel.edu, 302-831-4570

Michah W. Rothbart

mwrothba@syr.edu, 315.443.2868

Ying Shi

yshi78@syr.edu, 315.443.3114